

“ WITHOUT DESTRUCTION,
THERE IS NO CREATION...
THERE IS NO CHANGE. ”

Oda Nobunaga (1534–82)



Oda Nobunaga ruthlessly broke the military power of Japan's leading regional warlords in a drive for control that eventually united Japan.

BY ABOUT 1560, ODA NOBUNAGA, LEADER OF THE ODA CLAN in central Japan, was emerging as the greatest of the country's regional warlords, or *daimyo*. Since the calamitous Onin War, which began in 1466, Japan had been effectively ungovernable—the *daimyo* brutally vying for supremacy. The arrival of the Portuguese in the mid-15th century, bringing with them firearms, added to the chaos—the Japanese proved to be ready students of the possibilities of Western-style artillery bombardments (see 1574–77).

From 1561, the substantial Baltic territories of the Livonian Order (see 1236–40), which had already lost East Prussia in 1525 when the Teutonic Grand Master, Albrecht von Hohenzollern, converted to Protestantism, were progressively dismembered by Russia, Sweden, Poland, and Denmark. Originally a Crusading (that is, Christian) frontier entity, Livonia was a victim in part of the Reformation, but more of Polish-Russian rivalries—neither willing to see the other strengthened in the region at its own expense.

Few conflicts were more destabilizing than the French Wars of Religion, which began in



Massacre of Huguenots

The killing of 80 Huguenots at Vassy in northeast France in March 1562 was the spark that began the French Wars of Religion.

1562 and dragged on until 1598. There were, technically, eight separate wars; in reality, it was a single, long-drawn-out struggle. On one level, it was a purely religious conflict—was France to be Catholic or Protestant? Inevitably, this meant that the principal Catholic and Protestant rulers of Europe were periodically dragged into the conflict, neither the pope nor Philip II of Spain wanting a Protestant triumph any more than the Protestant rulers wanted a Catholic one. Yet it was also a matter of determining who exercised authority in France—the

crown or the nobles, whether Catholic or Huguenot. The French Protestants were known as Huguenots, from the Swiss-German *Eidgenossen* or “oath companions.” The Catholics were in the majority, but the Huguenots were exceptionally well organized. Both parties had powerful aristocratic leaders for whom the struggle was also political. A royal minority always brought political instability in its wake (see 1557–59), but from 1560 it was compounded by three successive kings who had very limited ability to manage the nobles. As none produced an heir and civil war intensified, what was at stake by the end was not just the country's religious destiny but royal authority itself.



Construction of the austere yet vast royal residence, El Escorial, began in 1563. It was intended to underline the piety as well as the majesty of Spain's rulers.

IN 1563, SWEDEN AND DENMARK CLASHED FOR SUPREMACY in the Baltic. The first modern naval war ensued—that is, with sailing ships, rather than galleys (as was still common in the Mediterranean), heavily armed with cannon. Both countries were competing for control of the maritime invasion routes, the Danes supported by the semi-independent German city of Lübeck. Seven major naval battles were fought between 1563 and 1570, by which point both sides were effectively bankrupt. As other countries would discover, custom-built men-of-war may have been the most formidably powerful weapons of the period but the ships were prodigiously expensive. The war ended with no territorial gain for either side.

Escaping persecution at home, in 1564 a group of Huguenot settlers established a colony in Florida on the banks of the St. John's River on the site of what today is Jacksonville. Called Fort Caroline, it was the first French colony in what would become the US. It lasted little more than a year before it was destroyed by a Spanish force determined not to allow French settlers, especially Protestant ones, to encroach on a territory where they enjoyed superiority. All the settlers and the relieving force, bar a number of women and children, were killed. In revenge, in 1568, a French force destroyed a Spanish colony, Fort Matanzas, built after the destruction of Fort Caroline.

Battle of Oland

The Danes were victorious at the Battle of Oland on May 30–31, 1564, during which the Swedes lost their new royal flagship, Mars.



44 THE NUMBER OF KNIGHTS WHO SERVED AS GRAND MASTER OF THE LIVONIAN ORDER

